

# Silver linings

**THE PAST TWO MONTHS HAVE PERHAPS BEEN THE WORST FOR THE WORLD SINCE THE SECOND WORLD WAR,** and there is plenty of negative news, discouraging stock market reports, gloomy predictions, etc., that you have already read or watched. We're so inundated with the negativity of it all, and feel so disconnected from one another because of lockdowns and insecurity about our jobs or businesses, that depression is rising fast. I refuse to be a contributor to that...

Instead, I'd rather focus on all the good things that have come out of this pandemic. And there are plenty, if we will just recognise them. For starters, all of us suddenly re-discovered the importance of hand-hygiene, and are all essentially germaphobes now. We reconnected with our families, especially the older folks, and spent more time with the people who really matter. The huge amounts of reduced vehicular traffic is making air more breathable in large cities across the world, which is doubly true for the biggest cities in India. I'm sure you can add many more general positives to this list yourselves.

Personally speaking, since I live in Australia, and work from home, the change brought by the lockdown is not as drastic for me. I have to try and empathise with your experiences by listening to what my family, friends and colleagues who are living through it have to say. However, that is the biggest change for me... connecting more often with friends, family... talking on the phone to relatives who are elderly, connecting with friends over video chat, or even just the usual WhatsApp groups. I even reconnected with old school friends this month, and found out there is a 25-year reunion planned. I didn't even know it had been 25 years since I was in school, which shows how disconnected I really was from so many people!

Then again, I'm not really a people-person, and so many of my friends tagged me when they posted the "I was practicing social distancing long before coronavirus" meme. I really should change that facet of myself, and maybe that's a post-covid resolution I should make.

I also took time out to remember and thank Babbage, Turing, Berners-Lee and so many others who played such a vital role in inventing the tech that allows the world to remain functional in these times. We were still able to reach so many thousands of you through our digital magazine because of all these heroes of computing. So many of you will still be reading this in digital

format because perhaps you live in a "red zone" according to the government's classification of hotspots. I still hope to be able to print this issue and get it sent out to you.

Despite no change in workload for me, I did find myself with a little more time on the weekends, as we couldn't make plans to go out anywhere. That extra time was promptly put to use by completing some DIY projects around the house that I had promised my wife I would complete months ago (and, in some cases, I am ashamed to admit, even years ago!). And of course I had to find time to indulge in some retro gaming. I'd bought a Pi 3, and all the necessary components, but never found the time to put it all together. I spent one whole Saturday playing ancient Nes and SNes games, much to the delight of my 6-year old.

I cleaned out my computer – physically, by removing everything from the cabinet and dusting it down, which led to it running a lot cooler than before. I also cleaned out the HDD – nothing is more satisfying than a computer that boots and behaves almost like a freshly installed one. That said, I also have a pending upgrade to do, and have to convert my existing setup to liquid cooling, which I am going to do immediately after this issue is done.

I've also dusted off my guitar, found new strings just lying in a drawer somewhere and plan on getting back to that on a semi-regular basis. Nothing like a pandemic to remind you of how little time you might have left, and how you have ignored your old passions. A pandemic also reminds you about how badly out of shape you are – which is the curse of us editors and writers who make a living by sitting on our butts at a PC. That's something a lot of you will be able to empathise with now, because of the work / study from home trend that's been forced on us. Please make it a point to get 30 minutes of aerobic exercise a day to keep your body fit and circulate blood – even if it's just by dancing madly to your favourite tunes.

While I empathise and weep with all of you who have tragically lost a loved one, and do not at all want to downplay the suffering of those who have been infected, or even those who are terrified of this horrible disease... I'm just looking for the silver linings in the dark clouds, and if you're like me, please share your silver linings – we'd love to share it with everyone else in next month's 19th anniversary issue. 📖



**"I also took time out to remember and thank Babbage, Turing, Berners-Lee and so many others who played such a vital role in allowing the world to maintain some sort of semblance of functionality in these times."**



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